

Phishing Awareness & Prevention

Defending the Human Element in 2026

Phishing remains the primary entry point for 60% of all data breaches. As attacks evolve into AI-driven deepfakes and mobile-centric scams, staying informed is our strongest defense.

1.1 Million

ATTACKS IN Q2 2025

\$4.44M

AVG. BREACH COST

7.5%

AVG. STOCK DROP

Common Phishing Tactics

The Multi-Channel Threat Landscape



Email & Clone Phishing

The most prevalent vector. Attackers use **Clone Phishing** to copy legitimate, previous email threads, making their malicious follow-up appear as a natural continuation of a trusted conversation.



Smishing & Vishing

Mobile-based attacks via SMS or Voice. **Smishing** exploits the high open rates of texts, while **Vishing** uses caller ID spoofing and AI voice manipulation to pressure victims into revealing MFA codes.



Quishing (QR Codes)

A rising threat where malicious links are hidden in **QR codes**. These often bypass email scanners and exploit mobile browsers, which frequently hide the full URL from the user's view.



Deepfake & Whaling

High-level "Whaling" attacks now use **AI-generated video** or audio in live meetings (Zoom/Teams) to impersonate executives and authorize urgent, non-standard financial transfers.

Red Flags to Watch For

Identifying Deceptive Communication



Behavioral Triggers

Artificial Urgency

Demands for "immediate action" to prevent account lockout or legal consequences.

Secrecy

Requests to keep a transaction confidential or to **bypass standard approval processes**.

Unusual Pressure

Language designed to make the recipient act before they have time to think or verify.



Technical Discrepancies

Sender Mismatch

Display name says "Microsoft Support," but address is support@micr0soft-security.com.

Generic Greetings

Use of "Dear Valued Customer" or "Dear User" instead of your specific name.

Link Mismatches

Hovering reveals a destination URL that doesn't match the official company domain.



Process Anomalies

Unexpected Attachments

Receiving .iso, .js, or .scr files from sources that usually send PDFs.

Out-of-Band Requests

An IT alert arriving via personal SMS rather than internal ticketing systems.

Data Harvesting

Any unsolicited request for **passwords, MFA tokens**, or sensitive details.

Real-World Examples & Prevention Best Practices

The "Pause-Verify-Report" Protocol



Step 1: Pause and Inspect

When an urgent request arrives, **Stop**. Check for sender mismatches and hover over links. If a site lacks HTTPS, be wary—though 20% of phishing sites now use encryption.

Step 2: Out-of-Band Verification

Never use provided contact info. **Verify** by calling through an official directory or using the company's internal chat.

Step 3: Report and Sanitize

Use the "Report Phishing" button. This alerts security to **Sanitize** the network by blocking the malicious domain for all employees.

Step 4: Technical Hygiene

Always use a **Password Manager**; they won't auto-fill on spoofed domains. Ensure MFA is active on every sensitive account.

Quick Quiz Questions

Test Your Awareness



Scenario A

The Executive Request

You receive an urgent email from your CEO asking for a wire transfer change for a "confidential project." The email looks like a continuation of a real thread. **What is your first move?**

Type your answer...



Scenario B

The QR Code Update

A poster in the breakroom has a QR code for a "Mandatory Security App Update." You scan it, and it asks for your corporate login. **Why is this a high-risk situation?**

Type your answer...



Scenario C

The IT SMS Alert

You get a text: "Suspicious login detected. Click here to secure your account." The link is `company-it.bitly.com`. **What are the two primary red flags here?**

Type your answer...
